

Teching Their Breath Away

Japanese transport firms are using mobile technology to prevent drunk drivers from starting shifts. An alcohol breath analyser sends data to a service centre, a video call is made and a software confirms the driver's identity before the test



Sony Pumps Up The Blu-ray Volume

Sony Computer Entertainment Europe will send out half a million copies of *Casino Royale* on Blu-ray Disc to the first half-million registered PS3 users. Probably to promote the PlayStation Network, or to the format. Strike twelve (or fourteen) for Blu-ray



Escape

NEWS YOU CAN USE

Game On!

Assuming University of Rochester researchers can't be bribed by game publishers, it's official. You can tell your parents about it. You can tell them to buy you an Alienware rig and lots of original copies of games—for the sake of your vision, which, it's been proved, gaming improves. And no, it doesn't work with Tetris-like games (hence the Alienware rig): it only works with complex, action-packed games like *Unreal Tournament*.

You can quote the good researchers at the University of Rochester. They proved that students who played action video games a few hours a day for a month improved their performance by 20 per cent at a "clutter test"—something like a standard eye-test. (It should work for non-students too, we're assuming.)

Chosen for the research were students at the

University who hardly played games. It was a tough job, but they found some. Then those students were given the clutter test. This consists of the following: one needs to identify the orientation of a "T" thrown somewhere in a "clutter" of other symbols. Then, the students were divided into two groups—one group played *Tetris* for about an hour a day, and the other played *Unreal Tournament*. The official difference? The latter is more visually complex.

After a month, the Tetris-players hadn't improved and the UT players *had* improved at the clutter test.

So here's the head researcher's verdict: Daphne Bavelier says, "When people play action games, they're changing the brain's pathway responsible for visual processing. These games push the human visual system to the limits and the brain adapts to it."

And if that weren't enough, Bavelier goes on: "That learning carries over into other activities and possibly everyday life." Meaning—and it doesn't get any better—that gaming actually makes you smarter, too!

What next? Bavelier's team plans to use a 360-degree virtual reality lab being developed at the University. Now if they find something useful from that, we're not sure you'll be able to convince your folks to buy you a head-mounted display, but for now, you can show them this.

ROMANIA'S IT INDUSTRY

Thanks, Bill!

This is the first documented evidence of something like this having happened. Basescu told Bill Gates, "Thanks for all the Windows and Office installations!"

No, sorry. That doesn't quite make sense. We're

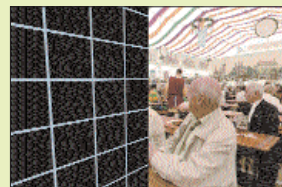
Whatever Happened To...

QTVR

QuickTime Virtual Reality (QTVR) was an interesting concept by Apple that allowed users to interact with images instead of just sitting there looking at them. It aimed to do away with the two dimensional viewing of images and instead, show everything in 3D. The technology is not dead, by any means, and you can still get the necessary tools from Apple to make QTVR MOV files, it's just that it never took off and became popular.

How it works is pretty simple: You shoot panoramic views of your surroundings—left, right, behind, top and bottom—then the software puts them together and makes a spherical 3D image that it displays as a movie. Now viewers (who have to have Apple's QuickTime Player) can just keep the left mouse button pressed and move the mouse left to see what's on the left, or right to see what's on the right, as well as up or down.

When seen in a browser (streaming) the images are loaded into the player one at a time, and you can clearly see the 3D grid that is being used. QTVR also offered companies the chance to show-off their products in 3D, letting the users rotate the product and view it from the desired angle. However, we suspect the capabilities of Flash killed all hope QTVR had on this front.



Win! My Desktop

February's Winner

Tarun Brari from Mandi, Himachal Pradesh

Is it Windows, Mac OS X or Linux? Turns out it's Windows, and here's how he did it:

1. FinderBar 1.3 for the Mac-Style taskbar
 2. Objectdock 1.3 for the Dock
 3. A SuSE wallpaper
 4. Hide the desktop icons—right click on the Desktop > Arrange Desktop Icons and Uncheck show desktop icons
- Almost had us confused, this did.

Participate in this contest

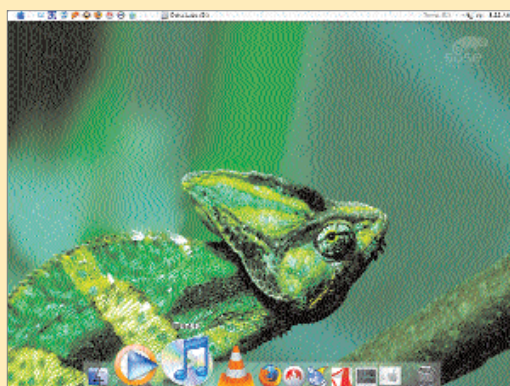
and win next month

Wireless and Mobile All-IP Networks

by Yi-Bing Lin & Ai-Chun Pang

Published by

WILEY-INDIA



Send in your Desktop with a description of how you made it to mydesktop@thinkdigit.com with the subject "My Desktop", and tell us your postal address, too.